surrounding cities. He built at least thirty mosques and schools, dug new canals and wells, ordered bridges and waterwheels constructed on the Nile: the sort of activity that could take place only in the absence of a treasury-draining war.

TO THE EAST, Al-Nasir's new ally, the khan of the Il-khanate, was fretting.

Still in his teens, Abu Sa'id was increasingly unhappy in his role as figurehead. Chupan had assured peace in the Il-khanate, but the young khan, like al-Nasir a decade and a half before, found himself pushed constantly into the shade by his efficient and hardworking regent: "Chupan took all the realms of . . . Abu Sa'id into the grasp of his authority and the hand of his control," writes the court historian Hafiz-i Abru.[8]

The khan began to suspect that Chupan, far from working to bring him into full power, was planning to install his own son as his successor, in a shogun type of arrangement that would leave Abu Sa'id entirely out of the circles of power. In 1325, he prodded hard at Chupan's authority. Chupan's daughter, the famous beauty Khatun, had two years earlier been married off to an Il-khanate nobleman; now Abu Sa'id summoned her father and demanded the young woman for himself. "For it was the custom of the Mongol house," says Hafiz-i Abru, "that should any lady please the king, usage required her husband to forgo her with a good grace."[9]

Abu Sa'id was a handsome youth ("The most beautiful of God's creatures in features," says Ibn Battuta, who passed through Baghdad after leaving Cairo and saw the khan with his own eyes), and the court historian Abru rather romantically chalks this demand up to love. "When the heart falls for a languid narcissus-eye," he sighs, "be it a king's or a slave's, it slips out of control."[10]

But the order was clearly an attempt to discover just how loyal to his khan Chupan actually was. When the vizier refused to order his daughter to obey, Abu Sa'id had his answer. He bided his time until Chupan was out of Baghdad, and then ordered Chupan's oldest son arrested and executed, on charges that the young man was sleeping with one of the khan's own concubines. Chupan, hearing the news, realized that a purge was upon him. He fled to the Il-khanate city of Herat, believing that the governor—a personal friend—would protect him. But the governor refused to defy the khan; instead, he offered his old acquaintance a choice between beheading and the more honorable death of strangulation.

Chupan chose strangulation. Afterwards, the governor chopped off one of his fingers and sent it to Abu Sai'd as proof of his obedience.[11]

Chupan's second son fled to Cairo, but al-Nasir was also unwilling to